The Ladder and the Interval

Interstitial Soteriology, Pharmacological Sovereignty, and the Dead Letter in Bruce Joel Rubin and Adrian Lyne's Jacob's Ladder *(1990)*

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Jacob's Ladder* (1990), directed by Adrian Lyne from Bruce Joel Rubin's screenplay, is neither a twist-ending psychological thriller, nor a Vietnam allegory dressed in metaphysical ornament, nor a filmed paraphrase of the Tibetan *Bardo Thödol*, though it has been received as each. It is a systematic cinematic theology of the interval. Against these partial readings I propose the framework of INTERSTITIAL SOTERIOLOGY: the claim that the film locates deliverance not at the summit of its titular ladder but in the gaps between its rungs. Seven such gaps organize the argument: the bardo (Tibetan *bar do*, the between-two); the Lacanian space between two deaths; the liminal phase of the rite of passage; the interval between projected frames; the postal interval between dispatch and arrival; the undecidable interval of the *pharmakon*; and the physical gap that every climber crosses only by releasing one rung to seize the next.

The argument proceeds through comparative religion (Genesis and its midrashim, Hekhalot mysticism, John Climacus, Dante, John of the Cross, the *Bardo Thödol* and its Western translators), continental philosophy (Eckhart, Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Levinas, Derrida, Agamben), psychoanalysis and transpersonal psychology (Freud, Jung, Lacan, Grof), media theory (Bazin, Kittler, Mulvey, Deleuze on Bacon), and horror theory (Douglas, Wood, Kristeva, Carroll, Creed, Lowenstein). Five findings result.

First, the film dramatizes Jung's 1935 proposal that Western readers traverse the *Bardo Thödol* in reverse, ascending from the bardo of becoming toward the clear light; the reversed bardo is itself a ladder. Second, its central doctrine, a dictum the film attributes to Meister Eckhart but whose textual source has proven elusive, formalizes a cross-traditional VALENCE AXIOM: the content of the threshold encounter is invariant, while its terror or grace depends on whether the subject grasps or releases. Third, Lyne's undercranked demonology locates the demonic in the interval between frames, rendering the cinematic apparatus homologous with the bardo (INTERFRAME DEMONOLOGY). Fourth, the conspiratorial plot of the military drug articulates PHARMACOLOGICAL SOVEREIGNTY, the state's claim to decide on the image-life of its soldiers. Fifth, the protagonist, a postal carrier with a doctorate in philosophy, named for the patriarch whose name derives from the Hebrew for heel and who was born grasping, is at once messenger and undelivered message, so that the film's double ending enacts a POSTAL ESCHATOLOGY in which the soul arrives while the political truth is returned to sender.

The dissertation concludes that the film issues a double imperative, *Gelassenheit* and *Zakhor*, release the self and retain the record, and it proposes VALENCE HORROR as a new category for horror theory: horror whose object is constant and whose dread is a function of the subject's grip.

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Swatches show the ground of each chapter's opening page, which lightens as the argument climbs.

Introduction

The Rung and the Gap

The film's title names three ladders at once. The first is the stairway the patriarch sees in his dream at Bethel (Genesis 28:10–22). The second is a fictional military compound, nicknamed the Ladder, which the film's chemist describes as engineered to drive its subjects down to primal fear and rage. The third is the tenement stairwell up which the protagonist, led by his dead son, finally ascends into light.

The narrative that binds them is well known. Jacob Singer (Tim Robbins), a Vietnam veteran working as a postal carrier in Brooklyn despite a doctorate in philosophy, is besieged by apparitions: faceless officiants, convulsing heads, a subway passenger with a half-glimpsed tail. With former comrades he pursues evidence that their platoon was dosed by its own command. The final sequence returns to the 1971 Mekong Delta prologue and discloses that the entire New York existence has unfolded within the dilated moment of his dying in a field hospital. A closing title card, paraphrased here, states that reports of experiments on soldiers with the deliriant BZ appeared in the press and were denied by the Pentagon.

Three readings and their limits

Three readings dominate the reception. The PUZZLE READING places the film in the lineage of Ambrose Bierce's "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890) and Herk Harvey's *Carnival of Souls* (1962) and treats the ending as an epistemic reversal in which the viewer learns a concealed fact. The ALLEGORICAL READING treats the demons as the return of a repressed national crime, situating the film in the Vietnam-era horror cycle theorized by Robin Wood and Adam Lowenstein. The DEVOTIONAL READING, licensed by Rubin's repeated testimony that the *Bardo Thödol* was his principal source, treats the film as a Buddhist instruction manual in cinematic form.

Each reading is accurate and each is insufficient. The puzzle reading mistakes a soteriology for an epistemology, since the revelation transforms the protagonist rather than merely informing the spectator. The allegorical reading treats the metaphysics as alibi, as though the theology merely dressed a political grievance. The devotional reading flattens a densely stratified syncretism, at once Hebrew,

rabbinic, Greek, Christian-mystical, psychedelic and pharmacological, into a single Tibetan source.

Thesis: interstitial soteriology

This dissertation argues that the film's coherence lies in a sustained and rigorous thinking of the interval. I call the resulting framework INTERSTITIAL SOTERIOLOGY. Its premise is that deliverance in *Jacob's Ladder* is located neither at the top of the ladder nor at its foot but in the gaps between the rungs, and that the same gaps generate both the film's horror and its grace. Seven intervals structure the argument:

1. The bardo, literally the between-two, the Tibetan intermediate state between death and rebirth.
2. The space between biological and symbolic death that Lacan located in Antigone and Slavoj Žižek generalized into a theory of the undead.
3. The liminal phase of the rite of passage, theorized by Arnold van Gennep (1909) and Victor Turner (1964) as the condition of being betwixt and between.
4. The interval between frames, in which cinematic motion is produced and, in this film, the demonic is manufactured.
5. The postal interval between dispatch and arrival, where Jacques Derrida located the structural possibility of non-arrival.
6. The pharmacological interval of the *pharmakon*, undecidable between poison and cure.
7. The physical gap between rungs, which no climber crosses without releasing a grip.

Method and corpus

The corpus is the 1990 theatrical release. The published screenplay and the sequences reportedly excised after test screenings are treated as paratext rather than as a truer film. Rubin's thanatological corpus, comprising the story for *Brainstorm* (1983), *Ghost* (1990) and *My Life* (1993), and Lyne's features, notably *Flashdance* (1983), *9½ Weeks* (1986) and *Fatal Attraction* (1987), supply auteurist context.

The film is approached as a dialectical collaboration between a screenwriter of the soul and a director of the flesh. Rubin's script supplies the metaphysical architecture; Lyne's camera, schooled in the sensuous surfaces of advertising, supplies the somatic terror without which the metaphysics would remain homiletic. Throughout, the film's dialogue is described rather than reproduced, and secondary sources are paraphrased.

An ethical caution

Releasement, the film's highest value, is neither a counsel of resignation or despair nor a valorization of death. In Eckhart, in the Tibetan bardo literature, and in the hospice tradition the film anticipates, it names a non-grasping relation to experience that is cultivated in living and only consummated in dying. The film's own ending insists on the distinction, since it releases the self while refusing to release the truth.

Plan of the work

Chapter 1 reconstructs the genealogy of the ladder from Bethel to the *Tractatus*. Chapter 2 reads the film as a reversed *Bardo Thödol* mediated by its Western translators and by the psychedelic thanatology of the 1960s. Chapter 3 examines the Eckhart dictum, its insecure provenance, and the cross-traditional valence axiom it formalizes. Chapter 4 maps the film's katabatic topography onto Dante, shamanic initiation and the literature of the dilated instant. Chapter 5 develops interframe demonology through Bacon, Deleuze and Levinas. Chapter 6 analyzes pharmacological sovereignty. Chapter 7 reads the film as a postal eschatology. Chapter 8 situates it among the afterlife fictions of 1989–1991 and later. The Conclusion assembles the argument into the double imperative of *Gelassenheit* and *Zakhor* and proposes the category of valence horror.

Chapter 1

Genealogies of the Ladder: From Bethel to the *Tractatus*

The ladder has been double from its first appearance: an instrument of ascent and descent, blessing and fear, sacred vision and technical apparatus. *Jacob's Ladder* inherits this doubleness whole, and its title binds a soteriological ladder to a pharmacological one.

1.1 *Bethel and Peniel: the grasper's dream*

Genesis 28:10–22 narrates the patriarch's flight from Esau, his night at a nameless place with a stone for a pillow, and his dream of a *sullam* set on the earth with its top reaching heaven, on which messengers of God ascend and descend. The noun occurs nowhere else in the Hebrew Bible. Philologists have compared it with the Akkadian *simmiltu*, a stair, and with the stepped ramps of Mesopotamian temple towers, which would make the vision a ziggurat seen from below.

Source criticism distributes the episode between Yahwistic and Elohistic strands, and the composite already holds the tension the film exploits: a vision of traffic, angels in motion, and a vision of presence, the deity standing over the sleeper. On waking, Jacob names the site Beth-El, the house of God and the gate of heaven. The text adds that the place was formerly called Luz (Genesis 28:19), a detail that returns in Chapter 3.

The rabbis noticed the order of the verbs. The messengers ascend first and descend second, which implies they were already on earth. Genesis Rabbah 68:12 offers several resolutions, one of which is decisive for cinema: the angels ascended to compare the sleeping man's face with the likeness of Jacob engraved on the divine Throne, and descended to gaze upon the original. In this midrash the human face is the hinge between heaven and earth. Chapter 5 argues that the film's demons are precisely faces rendered impossible to face.

A second midrash, transmitted in Leviticus Rabbah 29:2 and its parallels, is the most important ancient commentary on the film. God shows Jacob the guardian princes of the nations climbing the ladder and falling, and invites him to climb. Jacob, afraid that he too will fall, declines, and the midrash reads Israel's later subjugation as the price of that fear. The first sustained exegesis of the ladder is therefore a meditation on fear as the obstacle to ascent. Jacob Singer's narrative can be read as the midrash's second chance: a Jacob offered the climb again, in extremis, and this time permitted to overcome the fear that stalled his namesake.

The patriarch's name sharpens the point. Genesis 25:26 derives *Ya'aqov* from *'aqev*, heel, because he emerged from the womb grasping his twin's heel, and Esau's bitter pun in Genesis 27:36 rereads the name as supplanter. Jacob is the patriarch of grasping. His defining encounter at Peniel (Genesis 32:22–32) consummates the identity. He wrestles a nocturnal assailant until daybreak, refuses to let go without a blessing, suffers a dislocated hip, and is renamed Israel, the one who strives with God.

Biblical Jacob is blessed for refusing to release. The film enacts an anti-Peniel. Its Jacob suffers a displaced back, and the figure the film codes as angelic, the chiropractor Louis, does not dislocate but resets, so that the blessing arrives through release rather than retention. Rubin, a Jewish-born screenwriter formed by Asian contemplative practice, rewrites the founding scene of Israelite tenacity through a soteriology of non-grasping. The Buddhist diagnosis of craving (*tṛṣṇā*) and clinging (*upādāna*) is thereby inscribed in the protagonist's Hebrew name.

1.2 *The Greek ladder: metaxy, the scale of love, and the way up and down*

Heraclitus supplies the ladder's logic in a single fragment (DK B60): the road up and the road down are one and the same. T. S. Eliot set the fragment as an epigraph to *Burnt Norton*, and it serves equally as an epigraph to the film, whose pharmacological descent and contemplative ascent prove to be one road.

Plato supplies the ladder's population. In the *Symposium* (202e–203a), Diotima defines the daimonic as the intermediate (*metaxy*) between gods and mortals, whose office is to interpret and to ferry across (*diaporthmeuein*, the verb of the ferryman), carrying prayers upward and commands downward. The daimonic is a courier service, a ladder of messengers. Later in the same speech (210a–212a) she describes the graded ascent from beautiful bodies to beauty itself, the figure later tradition called the *scala amoris*.

Philo of Alexandria's *De Somniis* I allegorizes Jacob's ladder three ways: as the air, peopled by disembodied souls; as the human soul, whose foot is sense-perception and whose head is pure mind; and as the rise and fall of human fortunes. Each reading reappears in the film, as the populated air of the demonic, the stratified psyche, and the vicissitudes of a ruined life.

Late antiquity turned the ladder into a checkpoint. Origen's *Contra Celsum* (VI.22) preserves Celsus's account of the Mithraic seven-gated ladder of planetary metals through which the soul ascends, and the same book (VI.30–31) reports Ophite diagrams in which the soul recites passwords to hostile archons at

each sphere. Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) made this the paradigm of Gnostic soteriology: the cosmos as prison, its rulers as jailers, ascent as an itinerary of interrogations. The faceless clerks, physicians, lawyers and agents who obstruct Jacob Singer are archons in this precise sense. The film's distinctive wager is that the password is not a word but a gesture, the opening of the hand.

1.3 *The monastic ladder: Climacus, the Sinai icon, and the descenders to the chariot*

John Climacus's seventh-century *Ladder of Divine Ascent* organizes the monastic life into thirty rungs. Its twelfth-century icon at Saint Catherine's Monastery on Sinai is the most exact premodern prototype of the film's drama. Monks climb a diagonal ladder toward Christ while dark winged demons drag some from the rungs with hooks and arrows into a gaping mouth below. The ascent is conducted under demonic harassment, and every fall is a failure of grip. Kierkegaard took the pseudonym Johannes Climacus from this author; the film's protagonist, a doctor of philosophy, is a Climacus who has abandoned the ladder of argument for the anonymity of a mailroom.

The Hekhalot literature, which Gershom Scholem reconstructed in *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (1941), names its adepts *yordei merkavah*, descenders to the chariot, although their journey is an ascent through seven heavenly palaces. The paradox restates Heraclitus: one descends in order to rise. The palaces are guarded by angels who repel the unworthy, and the Babylonian Talmud (Hagigah 14b) preserves the warning that an adept who mistakes the gleaming marble of the palace for water will be turned back. Misrecognition is lethal and recognition is passage.

The same tractate tells of four sages who entered the orchard (*pardes*) of mystical speculation. One died, one went mad, one apostatized, and only Akiva entered in peace and left in peace. Chapter 6 reads this as an ancient casualty report on unprepared visionary ascent, and the military drug as a chemical *pardes* into which unprepared men are forced. The Hekhalot adept, moreover, ascends by chanting hymns. The protagonist's surname, Singer, may be coincidental; the convergence is not.

1.4 *The scholastic and mystical ladder: Dante and John of the Cross*

Dante's *Commedia* encodes the entire structure the film traverses. In *Paradiso* XXI–XXII, in the heaven of Saturn reserved for contemplatives, a golden ladder rises

beyond sight, and Saint Benedict identifies it as the ladder Jacob saw, lamenting that no one now lifts a foot from the earth to climb it. Purgatory is a mountain of terraces joined by stairs, at each of which an angel effaces a mark of sin. The lowest circle of hell, Cocytus, is ice. Chapter 4 maps the film's fever and ice bath onto Cocytus and its closing stairwell onto the Purgatorial and Saturnine ladders.

John of the Cross supplies the ladder's disguise. The second stanza of his poem on the dark night describes the soul's escape by a secret ladder, disguised. His commentary (*Dark Night* II.18–20) adapts a ten-step mystical ladder and insists that on it one descends in order to ascend. Earlier (II.5 and II.10) he explains why divine light is experienced by the unpurified soul as darkness and torment, comparing purgation to fire that first blackens, cracks and fouls a damp log before transforming it into flame. The disguise matters for interpretation: the film's ladder is disguised as a conspiracy thriller, and the genre's apparatus of clues, informants and cover-ups is the dark night's cloak.

1.5 *Visual ladders: Bosch and Blake*

Hieronymus Bosch's *Ascent of the Blessed*, one of the early sixteenth-century panels known as *Visions of the Hereafter*, shows angels conducting naked souls toward a luminous tunnel, the iconographic ancestor of the near-death tunnel and of the film's final ascent. William Blake's watercolor *Jacob's Dream* (c. 1805) renders the ladder as a spiral staircase winding into a solar disk, a choice the film repeats when it replaces the ladder with a stairwell flooded with light. Blake's *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (c. 1790–1793), in which angels and devils exchange their values, is the Romantic precedent for the film's reversals of the demonic and the angelic.

1.6 *Modern ladders: Wittgenstein, the spiritual, the machine*

At the close of the *Tractatus* (6.54), Wittgenstein declares that his propositions elucidate by being recognized as nonsense once the reader has climbed through them, and that the reader must throw the ladder away after climbing it; the image has an antecedent in Sextus Empiricus (*Against the Logicians* II.481). The film's conspiracy plot is a Wittgensteinian ladder. Its clues must be followed, its informants believed and its explanation provisionally accepted, and then the whole explanatory apparatus discarded, because the final stair is reached only by abandoning the ladder of explanation.

The African American spiritual *We Are Climbing Jacob's Ladder* addresses its climbers as soldiers of the cross and promises that every rung rises higher. In the mouths of the enslaved, and later of the civil rights movement, the ladder became an instrument of collective liberation, and its fusion of soldier and climber anticipates the film's.

Finally, the ladder became a machine. The climbing electrical arc called a Jacob's ladder became an emblem of the cinematic mad laboratory, where the dead are reanimated by technical means. The folk toy of hinged wooden blocks produces the illusion of a block tumbling down its whole length, though nothing falls. Both are emblems of the film: the first figures technology's trespass on the threshold of death, the second an illusory descent produced by the mechanics of a hinge.

The genealogy yields the dissertation's first proposition. The title does not merely pun on a drug's nickname. It binds the soteriological ladder of Bethel, Climacus and Dante to the pharmacological ladder of the chemical state, and the chapters that follow argue that they are one ladder traversed in contrary directions.

Chapter 2

The Bardo and Its Western Relay

Jacob's Ladder is not an adaptation of the *Bardo Thödol* but a reversal of it. The film climbs the Tibetan sequence backward, exactly as C. G. Jung advised Western readers to do in 1935, and in doing so converts a liturgy of descent toward rebirth into a ladder of ascent toward the clear light.

2.1 *The text and its doctrine*

The *Bar do thos grol chen mo*, the Great Liberation through Hearing in the Intermediate State, belongs to the cycle of the peaceful and wrathful deities (*zhi khro*) revealed as treasure (*gter ma*) by Karma Lingpa in the fourteenth century and attributed to Padmasambhava. It is a liturgical text. A lama recites it beside the dying and then beside the body, instructing a consciousness that can no longer see the speaker.

The wider cycle distinguishes six intermediate states: of life, dream, meditative absorption, dying, reality-itself (*chos nyid*), and becoming (*srid pa*). The funerary core concerns the last three. At the moment of death (*'chi kha*) the ground luminosity dawns, and if it is recognized, that recognition is liberation. Unrecognized, it yields to the bardo of reality-itself, in which forty-two peaceful and fifty-eight wrathful deities appear in sequence, each an epiphany of the deceased's own awakened nature. Unrecognized again, consciousness drifts into the bardo of becoming, buffeted by karmic winds, pursued by terrifying apparitions, and drawn at last toward visions of couples in union and toward a womb.

The doctrinal core is a theory of recognition. The wrathful deities are the peaceful deities in wrathful aspect; both are self-appearances (*rang snang*) of the deceased's own mind; and the instruction repeated at every stage is to recognize them as such, neither fleeing nor clinging. Flight, terror and aversion drive consciousness downward, while recognition liberates at whatever point it occurs. The demonology of *Jacob's Ladder* follows this structure with a precision its critics have not fully registered. Its apparitions are not enemies to be defeated but appearances to be recognized, and the film's one explicit teaching scene, examined in Chapter 3, restates the Tibetan doctrine in the idiom of Rhineland mysticism.

2.2 *The Western relay*

The text reached the West through a chain of mediations that shaped what it could mean. W. Y. Evans-Wentz published Kazi Dawa Samdup's translation in 1927 under the title *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*, coined by analogy with the Egyptian funerary corpus, and thereby fixed its Western identity as a book of the dead rather than a manual for the living.

Jung's psychological commentary (1935; English 1957) reframed the deities as archetypes of the collective unconscious and made a proposal of decisive importance. Western psychology, he observed, had begun with Freud's sexual unconscious, the region the Tibetan text assigns to the bardo of becoming with its womb-visions. The Western reader should therefore read the book in reverse, from becoming upward through the archetypal deities toward the clear light, as an initiation rather than a descent.

The 1960s turned the text into a technology. Timothy Leary, Ralph Metzner and Richard Alpert's *The Psychedelic Experience* (1964) adapted it as a manual for guided sessions, translating death into ego-death, the lama's recitation into the guide's spoken instruction, and the conditions of a good passage into set and setting. Aldous Huxley, whose *Perennial Philosophy* (1945) had already placed Eckhart beside Buddhist sources, ended his last novel, *Island* (1962), with a dying woman guided toward the light by instructions to let go; his own death the following year was attended, by his widow's account, by a comparable recitation.

Stanislav Grof, working with psychedelic-assisted psychotherapy for terminally ill patients at the Maryland Psychiatric Research Center, synthesized the clinical findings with Joan Halifax in *The Human Encounter with Death* (1977). Chögyam Trungpa and Francesca Fremantle's translation (1975) completed the relay by insisting that the bardos describe the texture of ordinary experience as much as the post-mortem state. By the time Rubin drafted his screenplay, the *Bardo Thödol* had become, in American countercultural usage, a guide to any radical dissolution of the self, whether by death, drug or crisis.

2.3 *The film as reversed bardo*

Read against the Tibetan sequence, the film's visionary material runs backward. Its first movement is saturated with the phenomenology of the bardo of becoming: a consciousness drifting into a new and diminished existence, figured by the cramped apartment, the new partner and the menial employment of Jacob's imagined postwar life; the karmic winds of anxiety; and the party at which an

erotic dance resolves into a vision of demonic coupling, the textbook image of beings in union toward which the wandering consciousness is drawn. The second movement belongs to the bardo of reality-itself, as wrathful apparitions intensify toward the hospital sequence and its faceless officiants. The third movement is the moment of death proper, in which the ground luminosity, recognized at last, dawns at the top of a stair.

The film thus dramatizes Jung's reverse reading as narrative form. It begins where the Western psyche begins, in desire and its fear, and climbs toward the luminosity with which the Tibetan text begins. The reversed bardo is a ladder, and the title is exact.

The guides confirm the structure. In the Tibetan liturgy a lama reads into the ear of the dead; the film distributes this office between two figures. Louis supplies the reading, the verbal instruction that reframes the apparitions. Gabe, Jacob's dead son, supplies the luminosity itself. Here the film touches a refinement of Tibetan contemplative doctrine: the teaching that at death the child luminosity cultivated in practice meets the mother luminosity of the ground, and that their mutual recognition is liberation. The film alters the kinship term while preserving the structure. A father and son, separated by the son's earlier death, recognize one another in the light, and the final embrace is the meeting of the two luminosities rendered as family reunion.

2.4 *Grof's perinatal cartography*

Grof's *Realms of the Human Unconscious* (1975) organized the content of deep psychedelic sessions into four basic perinatal matrices modeled on the stages of biological birth. The film reproduces their sequence with notable fidelity, as the following correspondence shows.

Matrix	Grof's phenomenology	Corresponding movement in the film	Tibetan analogue
BPM I	Oceanic union, undifferentiated bliss	The remembered family idyll with Sarah and the boys	The luminosity as origin
BPM II	Engulfment, entrapment, no exit	The subway platform with locked gates; bureaucratic deadlock	Bardo of becoming
BPM III	Titanic struggle; demonic, sexual and purgative-fiery imagery	The party, the hospital, the fever and the ice	Bardo of reality-itself
BPM IV	Death-rebirth; light; release	The stairwell ascent with Gabe	Clear light at the moment of death

The correspondence is not offered as proof of influence. Grof's matrices and Rubin's screenplay draw on a shared 1970s phenomenology of dissolution. It clarifies, however, that the gurney's passage down a corridor strewn with human remains belongs to Grof's third matrix, the death-rebirth struggle in which the subject passes through a canal of horror, and that the final stair delivers not rebirth into another body but birth out of the cycle.

2.5 *The counter-psychedelic*

The Western relay prepares the film's most audacious move. Leary's manual used the bardo to guide a voluntary, prepared and accompanied dissolution of the ego toward unity. The film's military chemists, as their informant describes them, engineered the opposite: an involuntary, unprepared and unaccompanied regression of the ego toward rage, a molecule that takes its subject down the ladder rather than up. Set and setting are militarized, the setting a firefight and the set terror.

The Ladder is the counter-psychedelic, the dark twin of the 1960s project. The film's wager is that even this militarized delirium remains a bardo, that a consciousness forced into the intermediate state by its own commanders can still recognize what appears there and pass through it. Chapter 6 asks whether this wager absolves the state that administered the drug. The film's answer, carried by its coda, is that it does not.

Chapter 3

Releasement: Eckhart, the Apocryphal Postmark, and the Valence Axiom

The film's single explicit teaching is delivered by Louis after he carries Jacob out of the hospital. Attributing the idea to Meister Eckhart, he explains that the forces tearing at a dying person appear as devils to one who clings to life, and as angels freeing the soul from the earth to one who has made peace with death. This chapter argues that the dictum is the film's theological axis, that its attribution is philologically insecure in a way that illuminates the film's theory of transmission, and that it formalizes a cross-traditional law I call the valence axiom.

3.1 *Eckhart's doctrine*

Eckhart (c. 1260–c. 1328), Dominican preacher and master of theology at Paris, articulated a mysticism of detachment (*abegescheidenheit*) and releasement (*gelâzenheit*, from *lâzen*, to let). His sermon on the poor in spirit (Sermon 52 in Josef Quint's numbering) defines poverty as willing nothing, knowing nothing and having nothing, to the point of being free even of God as an object of desire. His treatise *On Detachment* ranks detachment above love. His *Book of Divine Consolation* argues that suffering accepted in God's will loses its bitterness, because its weight is borne by the one to whom the self has been surrendered.

Detachment opens the ground (*grunt*) where the soul's ground and God's ground are one and where the eternal birth of the Word takes place. Twenty-eight propositions drawn from his works were condemned in the bull *In agro dominico* (1329), issued after his death. The logic of the film's dictum is therefore authentically Eckhartian: suffering's sting is a function of attachment, and what afflicts the attached self is identical with what liberates the released one.

3.2 *The apocryphal postmark*

The verbatim source of the dictum has nonetheless proven elusive. No passage corresponding to it has been securely identified in the critical editions of the German or Latin works, and the attribution is best treated as a modern distillation of Eckhartian doctrine, possibly the screenwriter's own, as mediated by twentieth-century perennialism.

This is not a defect to be corrected but a datum to be interpreted. The film's central teaching travels under a sender's name that may be borrowed, and it

arrives anyway. Its authority is performative rather than philological, residing in its power to transform its recipient rather than in the authenticity of its signature. Chapter 7 develops this into the film's theory of transmission, in which truth is independent of provenance and salvation independent of authorship.

3.3 *The perennialist relay*

The Eckhart who can stand beside the *Bardo Thödol* without friction is a specific historical construction. Schopenhauer, in the second volume of *The World as Will and Representation* (1844), read Eckhart as a Western witness to the quieting of the will he found in Buddhist and Vedantic sources. Rudolf Otto's *Mysticism East and West* (1926) set Eckhart beside Śaṅkara, and D. T. Suzuki's *Mysticism: Christian and Buddhist* (1957) set him beside Zen. Huxley's *Perennial Philosophy* (1945) anthologized him among the witnesses to a single wisdom beneath all traditions.

Heidegger's *Gelassenheit* (1959) secularized releasement into a comportment toward technology and toward Being, and Reiner Schürmann's *Meister Eckhart: Mystic and Philosopher* (1978) read it as a wandering joy that lives without why. The film's Eckhart is the Eckhart of this relay. Its syncretism is less an idiosyncrasy than the precipitate of a century of comparative mysticism.

3.4 *The valence axiom*

The dictum's structure can be stated as a law. In liminal and post-mortem phenomenologies, the content of the encounter is held constant, while its affective valence, terror or grace, is determined by the subject's mode of holding, grasping or releasing. The law is attested across traditions with remarkable consistency.

TIBETAN. The wrathful deities are the peaceful deities unrecognized (Chapter 2).

RABBINIC. The Babylonian Talmud (Berakhot 8a) enumerates nine hundred and three kinds of death. The hardest is likened to a thorn wrenched backward through wool, the gentlest, the death by a kiss, to a hair drawn from milk. The difference between the images is the difference between snagging and slipping free, between a fiber that catches and one that does not. Later Jewish eschatology developed the *ḥibbut ha-qever*, the beating of the grave, a post-mortem ordeal that separates the soul from its attachments and whose severity is proportioned to how tightly the soul held the body and the world.

CHRISTIAN. John of the Cross explains that the divine light which is bliss to the purified is darkness and torment to the impure, and that the log blackens in

the fire before it becomes fire. Emanuel Swedenborg's *Heaven and Hell* (1758) teaches that spirits gravitate to hell by their own ruling love and experience the light of heaven, should they approach it, as pain.

TRAGIC. In Aeschylus's *Eumenides* (458 BCE), the Erinyes who pursue Orestes for blood-guilt are not destroyed but transfigured into the Kindly Ones through a civic act of reception. The same beings change valence.

LITERARY. In Tolstoy's *The Death of Ivan Ilyich* (1886), the dying man's torment is his struggle against being pushed into a black sack; when he ceases to resist, he falls through into light and his fear of death is gone. T. S. Eliot's *The Family Reunion* (1939) ends with its haunted protagonist recognizing that the Furies pursuing him are bright angels to be followed rather than fled. William Golding's *Pincher Martin* (1956) builds its purgatory from a drowned officer's refusal to relinquish his ego, which constructs an entire rock to stand on rather than accept the dissolving compassion that finally takes it.

HORROR. Clive Barker's Cenobites, in *The Hellbound Heart* (1986) and *Hellraiser* (1987), are presented as angels to some and demons to others. Barker relocates valence from attachment to appetite, since his seekers summon their tormentors by desire. The comparison clarifies Rubin's distinctiveness: in *Jacob's Ladder* the subject does not summon the demons; his clinging constitutes them.

PSYCHEDELIC AND CLINICAL. Huxley's *Heaven and Hell* (1956) observed that visionary experience turns infernal when fear and self-concern dominate. Bruce Greyson and Nancy Evans Bush's study of distressing near-death experiences (1992) identified a type in which the canonical features of the experience, light, separation from the body and movement, are present but experienced as terrifying. The valence axiom is thus a clinical observation as well as a theological doctrine.

3.5 *Louis and the vertebral ladder*

The figure who delivers the axiom deserves closer attention than he has received. Louis is a chiropractor, a practitioner of the hand (*cheir*), and his healing is a laying-on of hands. His rescue of Jacob from the hospital, lifting him from the gurney and carrying him out of a hell of clinicians, repeats the Byzantine iconography of the Anastasis, in which the risen Christ draws Adam and Eve from their tombs by the wrist. His physical care recalls Gerasim in Tolstoy's novella, the peasant servant who eases his dying master by bearing his legs on his shoulders and who alone accepts death as natural.

His medium is the spine. In yogic physiology the central channel (*suṣumnā*) running along the spinal axis is the ladder of the subtle body, up which energy ascends from base to crown. In rabbinic tradition (Genesis Rabbah 28:3; Leviticus Rabbah 18:1) the spine contains an indestructible bone called the *luz*, from which the body will be reconstituted at the resurrection. And Luz, as Genesis 28:19 records, was the original name of Bethel, the site of Jacob's ladder.

Whether or not the convergence was intended, the film assembles a remarkable constellation. A man named Jacob, at the symbolic site of Bethel-Luz, is healed in the spine by a healer whose name is a near-homophone of Luz, and released from the injury of Peniel by a hand that resets rather than dislocates. The spine is the body's Jacob's ladder, and Louis tends its rungs.

Chapter 4

Katabatic Topographies: Dante in Brooklyn

The film's New York is a katabatic space, a descent organized by thresholds, ordeals and frozen depths. Its geography maps with unusual exactness onto Dante's three realms, onto shamanic initiation, and onto the literature of the dilated instant.

4.1 *The dilated instant and the soteriological twist*

The film belongs to a lineage of narratives that unfold an entire subjective duration inside an objective instant of dying. Bierce's "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890) grants a hanged man an escape that occurs within the interval of the drop. Borges's "The Secret Miracle" (1943) gives a condemned writer a year of subjective time between the order to fire and the volley. Golding's *Pincher Martin* (1956) stretches a sailor's drowning into days of survival on an imagined rock. Flann O'Brien's *The Third Policeman* (written 1939–1940, published 1967) traps a dead narrator in a recursive afterlife he does not recognize as such. Herk Harvey's *Carnival of Souls* (1962) and Robert Enrico's *La Rivière du hibou* (1962), the celebrated adaptation of Bierce, gave the form its cinematic grammar.

Its experiential premise was documented early. Albert Heim's 1892 collection of testimonies by Alpine climbers who survived falls reported serene panoramic life-reviews in the seconds of descent, and Bergson's *Matter and Memory* (1896) cited the drowning person's sudden total recall as evidence that the whole past survives in memory. The first scientific literature of the near-death experience is, fittingly, a literature of falling.

The lineage divides, however, into two kinds of reversal. The EPISTEMIC TWIST, from Bierce to *The Sixth Sense* (1999), discloses a fact concealed from the reader, and its pleasure is the retrospective reorganization of clues. The SOTERIOLOGICAL TWIST, from Tolstoy and Golding to *Jacob's Ladder*, discloses a transformation undergone by the protagonist, and its demand is not reinterpretation but conversion. Bierce's hanged man dreams of survival; Jacob dreams toward acceptance. The film's final movement is not a trick but a delivery, which is why the medics' closing remark that the dead man looks peaceful functions less as a reveal than as a verdict on the passage.

4.2 *The subway as Styx*

The New York sequences open underground. Jacob wakes on a nearly empty subway car, glimpses beneath a sleeping passenger's coat what may be a tail,

finds the platform's exit gates locked, and crosses the tracks while the passengers of a passing train stare at him through the windows with altered faces. The scene compresses the classical threshold: the ferry of the dead, the guardian of the gate, the crossing of the stream, with the fare economy of the turnstile as a modern obol.

The locked gate belongs at once to Grof's second matrix of no exit, to Sartre's *Huis clos* (1944), and to Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915), in which a man waits his whole life before a door that was kept for him alone. The motif is Rubin's signature. In *Ghost*, released the same year, the subway is haunted by a violent spirit who teaches the dead hero to act upon the world. For Rubin, the underground is limbo.

4.3 *The party: the palmist and the vision of becoming*

At a party, a palmist reads Jacob's hand and tells him that his lifeline has already ended, that he is, in effect, dead. The scene is the film's first explicit annunciation, and its medium is the hand, the organ of grasping that the film will teach to open. The party culminates in the sequence in which Jezebel's dance dissolves into a vision of demonic coupling, identified in Chapter 2 as the signature image of the bardo of becoming.

Jezebel carries a dense typology. Her biblical namesake, the Phoenician queen of 1–2 Kings, persecutes the prophet Elijah and becomes in Revelation 2:20 the name of a false prophetess. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) supplies the horror-theoretical frame, and Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) the account of the abject as the zone where the subject's boundaries fail. Lyne's preceding films, *9½ Weeks* (1986) and *Fatal Attraction* (1987), had refined the erotic thriller's figure of the woman as object of desire and agent of threat at once.

Yet the film declines to complete the typology. Jezebel nurses Jacob through his fever and packs him in ice, and the film oscillates on her rather than condemning her. In the Jungian terms the film invites, she is the shadow-aspect of the anima and Sarah its matriarchal aspect. The protagonist's task is not to choose between them but to cease being possessed by either.

4.4 *The hospital as initiatory dismemberment*

The hospital sequence is the film's infernal center: Jacob strapped to a gurney and wheeled through corridors of the deranged, past floors strewn with human

remains, into a room where faceless clinicians bend over him. Two frames illuminate it.

The first is Mircea Eliade's account, in *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy* (1951), of the initiatory visions of Siberian shamans, in which the candidate is dismembered by spirits, his bones counted and cleansed, and his body reassembled. The dismemberment is the precondition of the capacity to ascend, and the ascent itself is frequently performed on a notched tree or ladder. The hospital is therefore initiation as well as hell: Jacob must be taken apart before he can climb.

The second frame is historical. Philippe Ariès's *The Hour of Our Death* (1977) traced the modern relocation of dying from the household to the hospital, where death became invisible, managed and denied, and Michel Foucault's *The Birth of the Clinic* (1963) described the clinical gaze that converts the patient into a field of signs. Lyne's hospital literalizes both, revealing the modern institution of death as a hell of faceless administrators. Louis's rescue, as Chapter 3 noted, is an Anastasis: the harrowing of hell is performed by a chiropractor.

4.5 *Ice: Cocytus*

The fever sequence is the film's descent to the floor of Dante's hell. Jacob's temperature spikes; his companions immerse him in a bath of ice; he wakes beside Sarah in his former life, tells her of a nightmare in which he lived with another woman, and then wakes again in the ice. In *Inferno* XXXII–XXXIV, the ninth circle is the frozen lake Cocytus, where traitors to kin, to homeland, to guests and to lords are locked in ice.

The film's ice is overdetermined in exactly these categories. Jacob's imagined life rests on a betrayal of kin, the abandonment of his wife and sons after his child's death. Jacob is also the victim of the gravest treason in the film's moral universe, the betrayal of soldiers by their own command. In the ice, betrayer and betrayed are frozen together in a single body.

The polarity of fever and ice rehearses the purgative extremes of John of the Cross's burning log and of Grof's third matrix, with its imagery of purifying fire. The false awakening beside Sarah is the circle's cruelest irony: in the depths of Cocytus the frozen man dreams of the warm bed he forfeited.

4.6 *Older descents*

The film's structure of progressive divestment recalls the oldest recorded katabasis. In the Sumerian *Descent of Inanna*, the goddess surrenders a garment or

emblem at each of the seven gates of the underworld until she arrives stripped and is hung upon a hook. Jacob is stripped in sequence of his lawyer, his comrades, his records, his physician, his partner and his explanations. The Orphic descent supplies the backward look: Jacob's retrospection toward his former family is the gaze that keeps him below.

The Egyptian weighing of the heart against the feather of Maat, in the funerary spells the Egyptians called the book of coming forth by day, supplies an image of lightness as the condition of passage. The criterion there is ethical rather than contemplative, but the image resonates with the film's ethic of release.

4.7 *The mirror film:* Angel Heart

The closest contemporary analogue is Alan Parker's *Angel Heart* (1987), produced, like *Jacob's Ladder*, by Alan Marshall, and like it the work of a British director formed in advertising. In both, a war-scarred man investigates a mystery that proves to be his own condition. In *Angel Heart* the devil appears as Louis Cyphre; in *Jacob's Ladder* the angel is named Louis. In *Angel Heart* the investigator learns that he was once the crooner Johnny Favorite, a singer who bargained away his soul; in *Jacob's Ladder* the protagonist is a Singer who must release his.

Angel Heart ends with its protagonist descending in an elevator; *Jacob's Ladder* ends with its protagonist ascending a stair. The two films form a diptych of damnation and deliverance, mirror images produced within three years by the same producer from the same vocabulary of steam and shadow.

Chapter 5

Interframe Demonology: Lyne, Bacon, and the Bardo of the Frame

Lyne's most consequential decision was to refuse the prosthetic monster. The film's demons are made not of latex but of time, of footage captured at a drastically reduced frame rate and projected at standard speed, and this technique places the demonic in the interval between frames, the precise cinematic analogue of the bardo.

5.1 *The director of the flesh*

Adrian Lyne came to features from television advertising. *Flashdance* (1983), *9½ Weeks* (1986) and *Fatal Attraction* (1987) established a style of diffused backlight, steam, smoke and tactile surfaces that critics associated with the British commercial directors, among them Ridley and Tony Scott, Alan Parker and Hugh Hudson, who reshaped Hollywood's visual grammar in the 1980s. With the cinematographer Jeffrey L. Kimball, Lyne gave the film a grainy, desaturated New York of wet streets and fluorescent interiors, and he grounded every apparition in a physically plausible space.

The result is the dissertation's auteurist dialectic. Rubin is a screenwriter of the soul, whose scripts return obsessively to the passage of consciousness through death. Lyne is a director of the flesh, whose films return obsessively to the body's appetites and vulnerabilities. Their collaboration produces a metaphysics felt as somatic terror, and a somatic terror that resolves as metaphysics.

Lyne also cut. Sequences reportedly removed after test screenings, among them, by the screenwriter's account, an extended episode in which Jacob receives an antidote to the drug and undergoes a harrowing withdrawal, survive as paratext. The cutting moved the film from illustration toward suggestion, from a cataphatic description of hell toward an apophatic restraint that names it by withholding it. The deleted material is the film's *via negativa*.

5.2 *The undercranked head*

The film's signature effect was achieved by having performers shake their heads violently while the camera ran at a drastically reduced frame rate. Projected at standard speed, the footage yields a motion of such velocity and smear that no human body could perform it. A related vocabulary of subliminal inserts, faces

glimpsed for a handful of frames, descends from William Friedkin's *The Exorcist* (1973).

The point is ontological. The effect does not show a monster; it shows a human head whose movement exists only between the exposures that captured it. The demon is what happens to a face in the interval between frames.

5.3 *Bacon and the Furies*

Lyne has acknowledged Francis Bacon as a principal visual source, alongside the staged photographic tableaux of Joel-Peter Witkin. Bacon's *Three Studies for Figures at the Base of a Crucifixion* (1944), which the painter associated with the Eumenides of Aeschylus, and the screaming popes he began painting after Velázquez's *Innocent X* at the end of the 1940s, supplied the film's grammar of blurred, spasming heads.

The Aeschylean lineage is significant. The Furies are the beings whose transfiguration into the Kindly Ones Chapter 3 identified as the tragic form of the valence axiom. Lyne's demons are Bacon's Furies, and the film's ending is their *Eumenides*.

Gilles Deleuze's *Francis Bacon: The Logic of Sensation* (1981) supplies the theoretical vocabulary. Bacon, Deleuze argued, dismantles the face in favor of the head, the face being a structured social organization of features and the head a zone of the body. His Figures escape figuration through the spasm, in which the body strives to exit itself through an organ, typically the open mouth. And meat is the zone of indiscernibility where human and animal meet. Lyne's hospital floor is Deleuzian meat, his vibrating heads are Deleuzian spasms, and his faceless clinicians are heads without faces.

5.4 *The face and the commandment*

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) locates the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose very expression forbids killing, and opens with the claim that war suspends morality. The film's drug, as its chemist describes it, is a molecule of defacement. It abolishes the face-to-face relation chemically, so that men who shared a foxhole perceive one another as threats and kill one another.

Lyne's demonology visualizes this operation. The vibrating heads are faces that can no longer be faced, faces from which the ethical summons has been shaken loose. The midrash that read Jacob's face as engraved upon the Throne (Chapter 1) here meets its negation. If the human face is the image of the divine,

the drug is iconoclasm conducted in the bloodstream. In *Jacob's Ladder*, the demonic is the defaced face.

5.5 *The bardo of the frame*

Classical film theory understood cinema as a medium of the dead. André Bazin's "The Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) traced the plastic arts to a mummy complex, the Egyptian impulse to preserve the body against time. Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) argued that technical media extend the realm of the dead as far as their capacities for storage and transmission reach. Laura Mulvey's *Death 24x a Second* (2006) located death in the still frame concealed within cinematic motion.

The film's technique completes this tradition by placing the demonic in the interval itself. Cinematic movement arises from the projection of discrete stills separated by intervals the viewer does not perceive, and bardo means, literally, between two. Lyne's demons inhabit the between-two of the film strip as the dead inhabit the between-two of existence. Their impossible movement is generated precisely by the time the apparatus excises between exposures, so that the film's metaphysics and its apparatus coincide.

I call this INTERFRAME DEMONOLOGY: the production of the demonic not by any object placed before the camera but by a manipulation of the interval through which the camera records. Its corollary is equally precise. The guide who receives Jacob at the end is rendered without temporal distortion, at the ordinary rate of life. Grace, in this film, has a normal frame rate.

5.6 *Afterlives of the effect*

The effect became a lingua franca of the late twentieth-century uncanny. The designers of Konami's *Silent Hill* (1999) and its sequels have acknowledged the film as a formative influence, visible in their convulsive nurses, their hospital otherworlds, and *Silent Hill 2* (2001), whose monsters are projections of the protagonist's guilt, a ludic bardo. Hideo Nakata's *Ringu* (1998) achieved its spectral gait by reversing footage of a performer walking backward, a cousin of Lyne's temporal manipulation. Music video and, later, digital glitch aesthetics absorbed the jittering head as a stock signifier of possession.

The 2019 remake, directed by David M. Rosenthal and relocated to the aftermath of the war in Afghanistan, was widely judged to have exchanged the original's interstitial metaphysics for the mechanics of a conspiracy thriller. The

dissertation's argument predicts this outcome, since the original's force resides less in its plot than in its theory of the interval.

Chapter 6

Pharmacological Sovereignty

Beneath its theology, *Jacob's Ladder* advances a political claim: the modern state has extended its sovereignty into the interior image-life of its soldiers, and this extension produces a form of death for which neither the vocabulary of sacrifice nor that of crime is adequate.

6.1 *The historical substrate*

The film's premise draws on documented programs. Between the mid-1950s and the mid-1970s, the U.S. Army's chemical research facility at Edgewood Arsenal, Maryland, exposed several thousand service members to a range of agents. Among them was 3-quinuclidinyl benzilate (BZ), an anticholinergic deliriant developed as an incapacitating agent. In parallel, the Central Intelligence Agency's MKUltra program (1953–1973) studied hallucinogens and other compounds for interrogation and behavioral control, at times on unwitting subjects. Both became public through the congressional and executive inquiries of the mid-1970s and the Senate hearings that followed.

The film's closing title card, paraphrased, reports that experiments with BZ on soldiers were described in the press and denied by the Pentagon. Allegations of its use in Vietnam have never been substantiated, and the film presents them as rumor rather than record.

The film's own pharmacology is mythic rather than clinical. Its chemist describes a compound designed to drive the subject down a ladder of regression to primal fear and rage, whereas the syndrome produced by anticholinergic agents is characterized above all by confusion and hallucination. The divergence is instructive. The film invents a pharmacology of the berserk, and in doing so turns a historical program into a myth about the state's desire to manufacture fury.

6.2 *Sovereign is he who decides on the hallucination*

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. The drug in *Jacob's Ladder* extends that decision inward. The chemical state claims the authority to decide not only on its subjects' life and death but on the content of their perception, on what they will see when they look at one another. This is PHARMACOLOGICAL SOVEREIGNTY: the sovereign decides on the hallucination.

Michel Foucault's account of biopower, in the first volume of *The History of Sexuality* (1976) and the lectures *Society Must Be Defended* (1975–1976), described a modern power that takes charge of life, making live and letting die. The drug exceeds this description, since its object is neither the population's health nor the individual's discipline but the phenomenal field itself; Bernard Stiegler's later term psychopower names the extension.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) supplies the most exact category for its victims: the figure of archaic Roman law who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide, and who may not be sacrificed. The soldiers of the film's platoon, killed by their drugged comrades, occupy exactly this zone. Their deaths serve no strategic end, will be honored by no rite, and will be charged to no one. They are neither sacrificed nor murdered; they are bare life produced by pharmacology. Achille Mbembe's *Necropolitics* (2003) extends the analysis to regimes that distribute exposure to death, and the coda's official denial is the bureaucratic signature of that distribution.

6.3 *Betrayal and the berserk*

Jonathan Shay's *Achilles in Vietnam* (1994) reads the *Iliad* alongside the testimony of American combat veterans and identifies a recurrent sequence: a betrayal of what is right by a person in legitimate authority, followed by grief and collapse into the berserk state, a condition of godlike fury and indifference to one's own survival. Shay's concept of moral injury names the damage such betrayals inflict. The film, released four years before Shay's book, literalizes his sequence pharmacologically. The command betrays its men by drugging them; the betrayal produces the berserk; the berserk produces the mutual violence in which Jacob is wounded by one of his own.

Robert Jay Lifton's *Death in Life* (1967), on the survivors of Hiroshima, and *Home from the War* (1973), on Vietnam veterans, supplied the vocabulary of the death imprint, psychic numbing and survivor guilt. The advocacy of veterans and clinicians contributed to the inclusion of post-traumatic stress disorder in the third edition of the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* (1980). Cathy Caruth's *Unclaimed Experience* (1996) theorized trauma as an event not fully experienced when it occurred, and therefore returning belatedly and repetitively.

The film's structure makes Caruth's claim literal: Jacob's entire Brooklyn existence is the belated experience of a wound he has not yet finished receiving. Freud's "Thoughts for the Times on War and Death" (1915) argued that the

unconscious does not believe in its own death, and *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) described the repetitive dreams of the war neurotic. *Jacob's Ladder* stages both. An unconscious that refuses to register its death constructs an entire life, and that life repeats, in disguised form, the night of the wound.

6.4 *The repressed state*

Robin Wood's "An Introduction to the American Horror Film" (1979) formulated the genre's basic structure as normality threatened by a monster that embodies what a culture represses. Adam Lowenstein's *Shocking Representation* (2005) described the allegorical moment in which horror cinema registers a historical trauma it cannot directly represent. The Vietnam-era cycle, from George A. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* (1968) to Bob Clark's *Deathdream* (1974), in which a soldier killed in Vietnam returns home as a revenant, figured the war as the return of the dead to the domestic sphere.

Jacob's Ladder closes the cycle by inverting it. The revenant is no longer the soldier returning to haunt the nation; it is the nation's secret returning to haunt the soldier.

6.5 *The pharmakon*

In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Socrates recounts the myth in which the god Theuth offers writing to King Thamus as a drug (*pharmakon*) for memory, and Thamus replies that it is a drug for reminding rather than remembering. Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) made the undecidability of the word, remedy and poison at once, the hinge of a deconstruction of Western metaphysics.

The Ladder is the pharmakon in its purest cinematic form: a poison designed to make men kill, which becomes the medium of its victim's release. The film refuses, however, to let the pharmakon's undecidability exculpate those who administered it. Its theology decides on the remedy; its coda decides on the poison.

The Talmudic story of the four who entered the *pardes* (Chapter 1) clarifies what is at stake. Ancient mystical traditions surrounded visionary ascent with preparation, guidance and selection because they knew its casualties: death, madness and apostasy. The psychedelic researchers of the 1960s rediscovered this knowledge under the name of set and setting. The chemical state abolishes all three safeguards and forces the unprepared into the orchard, and the film's platoon reproduces the Talmudic casualty list on a collective scale.

6.6 *Prolepsis: the Gulf*

The film reached theaters in November 1990, as American forces deployed to the Persian Gulf. In December 1990 the U.S. Food and Drug Administration adopted an interim rule permitting the Department of Defense, under specified conditions, to administer certain investigational agents to troops without individual informed consent. Pyridostigmine bromide, given as a pretreatment against nerve agents, was among them. The rule was challenged in *Doe v. Sullivan* (1991), and the agent later figured in investigations of the illnesses reported by Gulf War veterans.

No causal relation between the film and these events is claimed. The coincidence nonetheless demonstrates the film's proleptic structure: within weeks of its release, its premise of soldiers receiving an experimental compound from their own command had become a question of administrative law. The coda was a letter dispatched into the film's own future, which is the subject of the next chapter.

Chapter 7

The Dead Letter Office: Postal Eschatology

The protagonist of *Jacob's Ladder* is a letter carrier. The detail is usually read as a marker of downward mobility, but it is the key to the film's theory of transmission: Jacob is at once the messenger, the message, and the dead letter that has not yet arrived.

7.1 *Angelos*

The Greek *angelos* and the Hebrew *mal'akh* both mean messenger. The beings on Jacob's ladder are couriers, the ladder is a relay between heaven and earth, and Diotima's daimonic intermediaries (Chapter 1) are a postal service of prayers and commands.

The film's cast is a roster of messengers. Gabe bears the name of Gabriel, the angel of annunciation. Michael Newman, the chemist who delivers the truth about the drug, bears the name of the archangel whom Christian iconography shows weighing souls, and a surname that evokes the Pauline new man (Ephesians 4:24; Colossians 3:10). Hermes, messenger of the gods and psychopomp who conducts souls to Hades, presides over the whole.

Jacob Singer, a doctor of philosophy who has chosen to carry other people's mail rather than think, has become a pure conveyor of messages he does not read. The one he cannot read is addressed to himself.

7.2 *Dead letters*

Herman Melville's "Bartleby, the Scrivener" (1853) ends with its narrator relaying a rumor that Bartleby had once been a clerk in the Dead Letter Office in Washington, where undeliverable letters are sorted for burning. The narrator's closing meditation concerns letters sent on errands of life that arrive only at death. John Durham Peters's *Speaking into the Air* (1999) made the dead letter an emblem of communication's constitutive risk of failure and traced the Western dream of perfect, bodiless transmission to the figure of the angel. Michel Serres's *Angels: A Modern Myth* (1993) read modern networks of transport and telecommunication as an angelology. Jacob, the letter carrier who is himself undelivered, joins Bartleby among modern fiction's dead letters.

7.3 *Lacan against Derrida*

Jacques Lacan's seminar on Poe's "The Purloined Letter" (1956) concluded that a letter always arrives at its destination: the signifier's circuit determines the subjects through whom it passes and completes itself. Derrida's reply, "Le facteur de la vérité" (1975), whose title puns on *facteur* as both factor and postman, insisted on the structural possibility of non-arrival. *The Post Card* (1980) named this condition *destinerrance*: a letter can always fail to arrive, and this possibility is not an accident but a condition of its being sent.

Jacob's Ladder stages both positions and assigns each to a different letter. The SOTERIOLOGICAL LETTER arrives. Jacob's death, deferred through the entire film, is finally received, the message he could not read is read, and the Lacanian circuit closes on the stair. The POLITICAL LETTER does not arrive. The lawyer withdraws, the comrades recant, the records vanish, the informant disappears, and the official denial seals the envelope.

Jacob is a *facteur* in Derrida's exact sense, the postman of a truth whose delivery he cannot guarantee. The film divides its eschatology between a letter that always arrives and a letter that may never arrive.

7.4 *Rubin's postal corpus*

The postal structure organizes Rubin's work as a whole. In *Brainstorm* (1983), for which he wrote the story, a device records sensory experience, a scientist records her own death, the hero plays the recording back to experience dying, and the military seeks to weaponize the apparatus. The configuration anticipates *Jacob's Ladder* exactly: a technology for transmitting the experience of death, and its appropriation by the state.

In *Ghost* (1990), the medium Oda Mae is a switchboard between the living and the dead, and the plot is a sequence of messages delivered across the threshold. In *My Life* (1993), which Rubin also directed, a dying man records videotaped letters for a son he will not live to raise. Rubin's oeuvre is a postal eschatology. Its recurrent question is how a message crosses from the dying to the living, and its recurrent antagonist is the institution that intercepts it.

7.5 *The apocryphal postmark, again*

The Eckhart dictum of Chapter 3 now appears as the film's model letter. Its return address may be false; its contents arrive and transform their recipient. The

film thereby proposes that the authority of a teaching is a function of its arrival rather than its origin. The claim is at once the most Buddhist and the most deconstructive in the film, since both traditions locate meaning in function and relation rather than in essence.

7.6 *The coda as re-dispatch*

The closing title card performs the film's final postal act. Having delivered the soteriological letter to its protagonist, the film forwards the undelivered political letter to its audience, and the spectator becomes the *facteur*. The denial reported in the coda returns the letter to the public, its rightful addressee, and charges the viewer with its delivery.

The film's two endings, the soul arrived and the truth undelivered, are therefore not a contradiction but a division of labor. The protagonist must let go. The spectator must not.

Chapter 8

Comparative Horizons: 1990 and the Thanatological Turn

Jacob's Ladder is the darkest member of a cluster of afterlife narratives that appeared in American screen culture between 1989 and 1991. Its distinctiveness becomes legible only against that cluster, and against the longer lineages of psychedelic horror and mythological fiction.

8.1 *Annus mortis*

Within roughly eighteen months, American screens produced an unprecedented density of thanatological fiction.

Work	Release	Afterlife structure	Relation to the valence axiom
Always (Spielberg)	1989	A dead pilot lingers to guide the living	Release of the beloved as the condition of passage
Twin Peaks (Lynch, Frost)	from April 1990	The Black Lodge, a liminal realm of doubles	Imperfect courage turns the encounter annihilating
Ghost (Zucker; Rubin)	July 1990	A murdered man between worlds; light for the just, shadow for the wicked	Rubin's theology in romantic form
Flatliners (Schumacher)	August 1990	Medical students induce clinical death and return haunted	Unreleased guilt returns as apparition
The Exorcist III (Blatty)	August 1990	A dream of the recently dead in a celestial waiting station	The afterlife as transit
Jacob's Ladder (Lyne; Rubin)	November 1990	A dying soldier's dilated instant	Grasping constitutes the demons
Truly, Madly, Deeply (Minghella)	1990–1991	A dead lover returns to a grieving partner	Grief must release its object
Defending Your Life (Brooks)	1991	An afterlife tribunal that judges fear, not sin	The axiom as comedy

Four conditions converged. First, the end of the Cold War dissolved the collective nuclear eschaton that had organized apocalyptic imagination since 1945, and eschatology returned to the individual deathbed. Second, the AIDS epidemic, together with the hospice movement inaugurated by Cicely Saunders and the

conscious-dying literature of Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, Stephen Levine and Ram Dass, returned dying to public discourse.

Third, the near-death research of Raymond Moody's *Life After Life* (1975), Kenneth Ring's *Life at Death* (1980) and Michael Sabom's *Recollections of Death* (1982) had made the tunnel, the light, the life review and the meeting with deceased relatives into a popular phenomenology, while Maurice Rawlings's *Beyond Death's Door* (1978) insisted on its infernal counterpart. Fourth, the generation that had read the bardo as a psychedelic manual entered middle age.

Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973), and the terror management research it later inspired, provided the period's theory of why cultures conceal mortality; the 1990 cluster marks the moment the concealment failed. Within that cluster, *Jacob's Ladder* is the one work that binds private dying to public crime.

8.2 *Lineages of psychedelic horror*

Ken Russell's *Altered States* (1980), from Paddy Chayefsky's novel and loosely modeled on John C. Lilly's isolation-tank research, is the film's closest predecessor in psychedelic body horror: a scientist regresses chemically and physically toward primal matter and is recalled by love. *Brainstorm* (1983) supplied Rubin's own first version of the recorded death, and *Hellraiser* (1987) the ambivalent angel-demon. Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969), whose dead linger in a decaying half-life where a devouring presence feeds on them while a benign one guides them, has often been read as a technologized bardo. Gabe is the film's version of Dick's guiding presence.

8.3 *Afterlives*

The epistemic twist became a genre after 1999, with *The Sixth Sense* (1999) and *The Others* (2001), and the film's influence on the puzzle narratives Thomas Elsaesser called mind-game films is evident. Its truest heirs, however, are soteriological rather than epistemic. Marc Forster's *Stay* (2005) unfolds a dying man's last moments on the Brooklyn Bridge as a dream populated by the strangers around him. The final season of *Lost* (2004–2010) reveals its alternate timeline as a shared intermediate state in which the dead remember one another and let go together. These works descend from Tolstoy and Golding rather than from Bierce.

8.4 *Mythological fiction*

The valence axiom recurs in modern mythopoeia. C. S. Lewis's *The Great Divorce* (1945) opens with a bus queue in a grey town, from which the damned ride to the foothills of heaven and find its reality unbearably solid; their hell, Lewis suggests, is locked from within. The parallel with the film's opening is structural, since both begin with afterlife transit through a grey city.

Philip Pullman's *The Amber Spyglass* (2000) brings its heroine into a land of the dead guarded by harpies who torment the ghosts by shrieking their worst deeds, and who are transformed into guides when offered true stories instead. The tormentors become conductors: Aeschylus's Furies again, in the idiom of children's literature. Neil Gaiman's *The Sandman* (1989–1996) personified Death as a gentle elder sister, a psychopomp whose kindness reframes the terror of her office.

Norse myth supplies a final, unexpected parallel. The valkyries, choosers of the slain, conduct warriors who die in battle; they are the battlefield's psychopomps. The berserkers, warriors seized by battle frenzy, have long attracted pharmacological explanations, from Samuel Ödman's eighteenth-century fly-agaric hypothesis to Karsten Fatur's proposal (2019) that henbane, a plant rich in anticholinergic alkaloids, was involved. The latter hypothesis places the mythic berserker in the same pharmacological family as BZ.

Whether or not either hypothesis is correct, the convergence is telling. The oldest European image of drugged battle fury and the film's modern one share a chemistry of delirium, and both stand beside a figure who gathers the fallen. In *Jacob's Ladder*, the valkyrie is a child on a staircase.

Conclusion

Toward Interstitial Soteriology

Jacob's Ladder teaches that a ladder is climbed by letting go, and this is literally true of every ladder. No climber ascends who will not release one rung in order to seize the next. The ladder is an instrument of serial release, and the film's theology is written into the kinesiology of its title.

The heel and the rung

This observation resolves the tension identified in Chapter 1 between the biblical Jacob, blessed for refusing to let go, and the film's Jacob, delivered by letting go. The resolution is not the abolition of grasping but its rhythm. Climbing requires two hands, one that grips while the other releases, in alternation. The heel-grasper of Genesis is not repudiated but set into rhythm, so that the tenacity of Peniel and the releasement of Eckhart become the two hands of ascent.

The film's hell is the condition of a climber who will release no rung: who clutches the life he has lost, the family he abandoned, the explanation he pursues, and who therefore experiences each apparition as an assault on his grip. Its grace is the same apparitions met by an open hand.

The seven intervals reconsidered

The seven intervals proposed in the Introduction converge on this figure. The bardo is the gap between lives. The space between two deaths is the gap between Jacob's biological dying and his acceptance of it. The liminal phase is the gap between the soldier he was and whatever he becomes. The interframe interval is where Lyne's demons are born. The postal interval is the distance between the dispatch of Jacob's death and its delivery. The interval of the pharmakon is the indeterminacy between the drug as poison and as passage. And the gap between rungs is where each act of release takes place. INTERSTITIAL SOTERIOLOGY names the film's insistence that salvation is not a place reached but a crossing performed, again and again, in the between.

The concept also intervenes in horror theory. Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990), published the same year as the film, defined the monster through categorical interstitiality, its violation of the boundaries between living and dead or human and animal, building on Mary Douglas's analysis of anomaly in *Purity and Danger* (1966). Carroll locates interstitiality in the object of horror. *Jacob's Ladder* relocates it in the subject's position and in the medium's apparatus, and

finds there not only horror but deliverance. The same between that terrifies also saves.

Valence horror

I therefore propose VALENCE HORROR as a category distinct from monster horror. In monster horror, dread is a function of the object: its impurity, its threat, its categorical transgression. In valence horror, the object is held constant and dread is a function of the subject's mode of holding.

The genre has three markers: a reversible demonology, a teacher figure who reframes rather than defeats the apparitions, and a resolution by recognition rather than by combat. Its lineage runs through Aeschylus's *Eumenides*, Tolstoy's *Ivan Ilyich*, Eliot's *The Family Reunion*, Golding's *Pincher Martin*, the Black Lodge of *Twin Peaks* and Pullman's harpies. Its paradigm is *Jacob's Ladder*.

Gelassenheit *and* Zakhor

Valence horror carries a danger the film confronts directly. If every demon is an angel misperceived, the state that administered the drug becomes an unwitting minister of grace, and its crime is sanctified by its victim's release. A theology of pure releasement would end in quietism before injustice.

The film forecloses this conclusion through its double ending. The protagonist lets go; the coda does not. Two imperatives must therefore be held together. The first is *Gelassenheit*, Eckhart's releasement: let go of the self. The second is *Zakhor*, the biblical imperative to remember, which Yosef Hayim Yerushalmi's *Zakhor* (1982) identified as the core of Jewish historical consciousness: do not let go of the record.

Jacob, renamed Israel at Peniel, bears the name of a people of memory. Jacob Singer releases himself so that the film may remember for him. Releasement without remembrance becomes complicity; remembrance without releasement becomes the endless repetition Freud diagnosed in the war neurotic. The ethic of *Jacob's Ladder* is their conjunction.

Contributions

The dissertation offers four concepts for further use. INTERSTITIAL SOTERIOLOGY names a structure of deliverance located in gaps rather than termini, applicable to the post-1990 afterlife film at large. VALENCE HORROR names a subgenre defined

by the subject's grip rather than the monster's impurity. INTERFRAME DEMONOLOGY names the production of the uncanny through manipulation of the cinematic interval. PHARMACOLOGICAL SOVEREIGNTY names the state's claim to decide on the content of its subjects' perception, a claim the century's chemical programs made concrete and the film made visible.

Coda

In its final moments the film returns to its beginning. A son waits on a stair; a father takes his hand; they climb into a light that floods the frame. A cut returns us to a field hospital in 1971, where medics observe that the man on the table looks peaceful, and then to a title card that forwards an undelivered letter to everyone watching.

The film releases its protagonist and retains its accusation. That double gesture, the open hand and the kept record, is its contribution to the long history of the ladder, and the reason it remains, more than three decades after its release, among the most theologically serious American horror films of its era.

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Jacob's Ladder (1990); Bruce Joel Rubin; Adrian Lyne; interstitial soteriology; valence horror; valence axiom; interframe demonology; pharmacological sovereignty; postal eschatology; *Bardo Thödol*; bardo; intermediate state; Meister Eckhart; *Gelassenheit*; releasement; detachment; *Zakhor*; perennial philosophy; Jacob's ladder; Peniel; *luz*; *metaxy*; Hekhalot mysticism; *pardes*; John Climacus; Dante; Cocytus; John of the Cross; dark night of the soul; katabasis; psychopomp; liminality; initiatory dismemberment; shamanism; perinatal matrices; Stanislav Grof; psychedelic thanatology; counter-psychedelic; near-death experience; distressing near-death experience; dilated instant; soteriological twist; mind-game film; Francis Bacon; Gilles Deleuze; Emmanuel Levinas; the face; cinematic interval; mummy complex; Jacques Derrida; *pharmakon*; destinerrance; dead letter; Jacques Lacan; between two deaths; Giorgio Agamben; homo sacer; biopower; psychopower; moral injury; berserk; trauma theory; Vietnam War cinema; BZ (3-quinuclidinyl benzilate); Edgewood Arsenal; MKUltra; Gulf War; return of the repressed; abjection; monstrous-feminine; categorical interstitiality; horror theory; afterlife film; *Angel Heart*; *Silent Hill*.